

THE FUTURE OF 2046

FINAL PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS

SKILLS DEVELOPED: Speculative Design | Futures Thinking | Strategic Foresight | Scenario Planning | Trend Research | Futures Frameworks

PROJECT OVERVIEW

For this project, you'll work together in groups to explore **possible futures** in an industry of your choice using **futures thinking tools and frameworks**. Your group will then create a corresponding **business artifact from the future** (20 years from now), and present your process, scenarios and artifact to the class, in an immersive manner.

KEY CONCEPTS

Speculative Design / Design Fiction: A practice within Futures Thinking. Artifacts are tangible or visual representations of the future that help individuals and organizations to explore and communicate complex ideas about potential future scenarios in a **provocative** way. The objective of a design fiction artifact is to **provoke, invite debate, stir emotions, and spark discussion**.

Scenarios: Narratives or stories that describe a possible future in detail, based on different assumptions and drivers/trends. They are created through a process of research and analysis, and they help individuals to envision the future and understand the potential implications of different scenarios.

YOUR ARTIFACT MUST BE PROVOCATIVE & IMMERSIVE

Your business artifact should be provocative and immersive — it must actively involve the class. Think beyond a slide deck: websites, exhibitions, product prototypes, commercials, role-playing skits, workshops, or other immersive experiences are all welcomed. Your artifact should provoke thought, invite debate, stir emotions, and spark discussion. Part of your grade will be determined by the **creativity, immersiveness, and provocativeness** of your artifact, alongside its basis in research and evidence.

COLLABORATION & TEAMWORK

You **must work together synchronously** to ensure a **cohesive** final result. Each tool or framework used must be the basis of your future artifact and the scenario in which your artifact lives. You'll paint a picture of the world your artifact lives in based on the frameworks you used in class, and design the artifact.

Teamwork is part of this assignment. Check in often with your teammates. If any issues arise—scheduling conflicts, uneven workload, communication breakdowns—raise them early and come to me. Do not wait until the last minute. Problems that are flagged early can be resolved; problems discovered at the deadline cannot.

RESEARCH REQUIREMENT

All statements, scenarios, and your artifact must be grounded in research evidence from independent sources—not just AI. Excessive, undiscerning use of AI and generic AI responses will be penalized. You must use the databases we learned in class: Stylus, WGSN, Global Data Explorer, Statista. Include a comprehensive bibliography of all independent sources used for your research.

FUTURES THINKING RESEARCH PROCESS

Visual Compendium (w/ Research Sources)

SPRINT 1: FOUNDATION RESEARCH

Today — In-Class Sprint (April 27)

- ✓ **Industry/Area Definition** (what are we referring to [defining the industry], what characterizes this industry, what does this area encompass)
- ✓ **Current Industry Situation** (projected growth or decline, current major players, relevant audience/participants, a few important and relevant facts relating to the future state of your industry which will inform your future scenarios)
- ✓ **Identify & Research Trends** defining your industry
- ✓ **Key drivers and trends** (micro, macro, mega) that could significantly impact the industry's future, including changes in technology, social attitudes, political and economic factors, and environmental issues (STEEP)

SPRINT 2: FRAMEWORKS, SCENARIOS & ARTIFACT CREATION

Due Next Week — Progress Presentations + Feedback + Work Session

- ✓ **Develop a Futures Wheel** to map the main implications of 1 of these drivers — with third order consequences
- ✓ **Use Three-Step Rapid Forecasting** to identify the potential consequences of 2 other drivers that will apply to your future scenario
- ✓ **Cone of Plausibility (Futures Cone):** Develop three analyses (preposterous, preferred, and projected) and communicate each of the three with a highly detailed scenario specifically based on your research. Incorporate 1 Wildcard into your preposterous scenario.
- ✓ **Backcasting** — Use this tool for your preferred scenario planning
- ✓ **Business Artifact From the Future** — Must be related to a business. Either for an existing company or an imagined future company. Must be provocative and immersive.
- ✓ **Contextual Scenario** — Which “world” or scenario does your artifact exist in? What is it like? Is it preferred, projected, possible, or preposterous?
- ✓ Which current or emergent trends, forces, happenings are your scenario and artifact based on?

- ✓ Target Audience — Who is this for?
- ✓ How does it work?
- ✓ Artifact format: Website, exhibition, product prototype, commercial, role-playing skit, workshop, or other immersive ideas
- ✓ Presentation of artifact with process explanation

FINAL CLASS: PRESENTATIONS — MAY 11, 2026

All research, frameworks, and artifact work must be completed before this class. This session is dedicated entirely to final presentations. **Every member of the group MUST present. Absence = Automatic Failure.**

COMPENDIUM DUE: MAY 13, 2026

Submit your Research & Process Compendium, bibliography of sources (cite **EVERYTHING**), and Drive folder with all process docs. Must incorporate feedback from presentations.

THE DELIVERABLE: RESEARCH COMPENDIUM

Your final deliverable is a **Research Compendium** — a comprehensive, organized, well-categorized report or magazine-style document that includes everything listed above. Think of it as a visual portfolio piece: polished, cohesive, and evidence-based. The final project is a presentation of your artifact, the process in which it was born, and the evidence-backed scenario in which it lives.

YOU WILL HAVE 3 THINGS DUE

1 CLASS PRESENTATION (5 Minutes) — May 11

- **Set the stage for the futures:** Summarize your process: research and exercises, your scenarios and rationale for production of your artifact
- **Paint a picture of the future:** the future scenario context your artifact lives in
- **Presentation of business artifact:** What is it? How does it work? Who is the target audience? How did your research lead you to it? (Specifics & Insights)
- **Immerse the class:** Your presentation should be an experience — provocative, engaging, and designed to spark debate and discussion

2 BUSINESS ARTIFACT FROM THE FUTURE — May 11

Provocative, immersive, and grounded in your research.

3 RESEARCH & PROCESS COMPENDIUM — Due May 13

w/ Frameworks and Artifact Demo/Info. Must incorporate feedback from presentations.

MANDATORY: Every member of the group **MUST** present on May 11. Absence = Automatic Failure.

GRADING CRITERIA

You will be graded on:

Demonstration of logical process	Attention to detail & project adherence
Quality of research & independent sources	Critical thinking
Proper application of Futures tools & frameworks	Creativity, immersiveness & provocativeness of artifact
Completion of all assignment requirements	Professionalism, teamwork & cohesion
Presentation skills	Research-to-artifact cohesion

The research must present a cohesive link to your future scenarios and artifact.

SUBMISSION

Upload all materials to a folder using your group name:

[Google Drive Shared Folder](#)

TIMELINE AT A GLANCE

TODAY (4/27)	Sprint 1 — Group assignments, project overview, initial research (Industry, Trends, STEEP)
NEXT WEEK	Sprint 2 — Progress Presentations & Feedback, Frameworks, Scenarios, Artifact Creation. All work must be completed.
MAY 11	Final Presentations — All members must present. Artifact, process, and scenario.
MAY 13	Research & Process Compendium due (must incorporate presentation feedback)